

# Chinese Idioms: 15 Famous Chengyu with Stories, Pinyin & Examples

## Idioms About Effort and Hard Work

1. 守株待兔 (shǒu zhū dài tù) — "Guarding a Tree Stump, Waiting for a Hare"

**The Story:** A farmer in the state of Song saw a hare run headfirst into a tree stump and die. Delighted by this free meal, he abandoned his fields and sat by the stump every day, waiting for another hare. Of course, none came — and his crops withered.

- **Characters:** 守株待兔
- **Pinyin:** shǒu zhū dài tù
- **Meaning:** Relying on luck instead of hard work; waiting for a windfall that will never come
- **Example:** 你不能守株待兔，要主动找工作。(Nǐ bù néng shǒu zhū dài tù, yào zhǔ dòng zhǎo gōng zuò.) — "You can't just sit and wait for luck — go out and find a job."

2. 铁杵磨成针 (tiě chǔ mó chéng zhēn) — "Grinding an Iron Rod into a Needle"

**The Story:** The young poet Li Bai once tried to quit his studies. On his way home, he met an old woman grinding a thick iron rod on a stone. When he asked what she was doing, she said she was making a sewing needle. Li Bai realized that persistence conquers all and returned to his books.

- **Characters:** 铁杵磨成针
- **Pinyin:** tiě chǔ mó chéng zhēn
- **Meaning:** With enough persistence, any goal is achievable
- **Example:** 学中文就像铁杵磨成针，坚持下去就会成功。(Xué zhōng wén jiù xiàng tiě chǔ mó chéng zhēn, jiān chí xià qù jiù huì chéng gōng.) — "Learning Chinese is like grinding an iron rod into a needle — keep at it and you'll succeed."

3. 愚公移山 (yú gōng yí shān) — "The Foolish Old Man Moves Mountains"

**The Story:** An elderly man named Yu Gong lived behind two massive mountains that blocked his path. He decided to move them, shovel by shovel. When others laughed at him, he said his children and grandchildren would continue the work. The gods were so moved by his determination that they sent giants to carry the mountains away.

- **Characters:** 愚公移山
- **Pinyin:** yú gōng yí shān
- **Meaning:** Unwavering determination can overcome any obstacle
- **Example:** 只要有愚公移山的精神，什么困难都能克服。(Zhǐ yào yǒu yú gōng yí shān de jīng shén, shén me kùn nán dōu néng kè fú.) — "With the spirit of Yu Gong moving mountains, any difficulty can be overcome."

## Idioms About Mistakes and Foolishness

4. 画蛇添足 (huà shé tiān zú) — "Drawing a Snake and Adding Feet"

**The Story:** Several men competed for a jug of wine by drawing snakes. The fastest finisher, feeling smug, decided to add feet to his snake while waiting for the others. When challenged, he lost — because snakes don't have feet, so his drawing was no longer a snake.

- **Characters:** 画蛇添足
- **Pinyin:** huà shé tiān zú
- **Meaning:** Ruining something by adding unnecessary details; overdoing it
- **Example:** 你的文章已经很好了，别画蛇添足了。(Nǐ de wén zhāng yǐ jīng hěn hǎo le, bié huà shé tiān zú le.) — "Your essay is already great — don't overdo it."

5. 掩耳盗铃 (yǎn ěr dào líng) — "Covering Your Ears While Stealing a Bell"

**The Story:** A thief wanted to steal a bronze bell but knew it would ring loudly when moved. His solution? Cover his own ears. He thought that if *he* couldn't hear it, no one else could either.

- **Characters:** 掩耳盗铃
- **Pinyin:** yǎn ěr dào líng
- **Meaning:** Deceiving yourself; ignoring a problem doesn't make it disappear
- **Example:** 不复习就去考试，简直是掩耳盗铃。(Bù fù xí jù qù kǎo shì, jiǎ zhǐ shì yǎn ěr dào líng.) — "Taking the exam without studying is just fooling yourself."

6. 刻舟求剑 (kè zhōu qiú jiàn) — "Carving a Mark on the Boat to Find a Sword"

**The Story:** A man dropped his sword into a river while crossing by boat. Instead of diving in immediately, he carved a mark on the side of the boat where the sword fell. When the boat docked, he jumped in at the mark — but the boat had moved, and the sword was long gone.

- **Characters:** 刻舟求剑
- **Pinyin:** kè zhōu qiú jiàn
- **Meaning:** Clinging to outdated methods; failing to adapt to change
- **Example:** 市场变了还用老办法，这是刻舟求剑。(Shì chǎng biàn le hái yòng lǎo bàn fǎ, zhè shì kè zhōu qiú jiàn.) — "The market has changed but you're still using the old approach — that's like carving the boat to find the sword."

## Idioms About Wisdom and Strategy

7. 对牛弹琴 (duì niú tán qín) — "Playing a Lute to a Cow"

**The Story:** A musician once played a beautiful piece for a cow, which continued chewing grass without any reaction. The problem wasn't the music — it was the audience.

- **Characters:** 对牛弹琴
- **Pinyin:** duì niú tán qín
- **Meaning:** Talking to the wrong audience; wasting your effort on someone who can't appreciate it
- **Example:** 跟他讲量子物理就是对牛弹琴。(Gēn tā jiǎng liàng zǐ wù lǐ jiù shì duì niú tán qín.) — "Explaining quantum physics to him is like playing a lute to a cow."

8. 塞翁失马 (sài wēng shī mǎ) — "The Old Man at the Border Loses His Horse"

**The Story:** An old man's horse ran away. His neighbors offered sympathy, but he said, "How do you know this isn't a blessing?" The horse returned with a wild stallion. His son rode it, broke his leg, and was spared from military conscription. Each misfortune led to fortune, and vice versa.

- **Characters:** 塞翁失马
- **Pinyin:** sài wēng shī mǎ
- **Meaning:** A blessing in disguise; you never know what fortune or misfortune will bring
- **Example:** 没被录取也许是塞翁失马，你可能找到更好的机会。(Méi bèi lù qǔ yě xǔ shì sài wēng shī mǎ, nǐ kě néng zhǎo dào gèng hǎo de jī huì.) — "Not being admitted might be a blessing in disguise — you could find an even better opportunity."

9. 狐假虎威 (hú jiǎ hǔ wēi) — "The Fox Borrows the Tiger's Fierceness"

**The Story:** A fox caught by a tiger claimed to be king of all animals. "Walk behind me," the fox said, "and see how every animal runs." The tiger agreed. All the animals fled — but from the tiger, not the fox.

- **Characters:** 狐假虎威
- **Pinyin:** hú jiǎ hǔ wēi
- **Meaning:** Bullying others by riding on someone else's power
- **Example:** 他只是狐假虎威，真正做决定的是他老板。(Tā zhǐ shì hú jiǎ hǔ wēi, zhēn zhèng zuò jué dìng de shì tā lǎo bǎn.) — "He's just borrowing his boss's authority — the real decision-maker is his boss."

## Idioms About Learning and Growth

10. 亡羊补牢 (wáng yáng bǔ láo) — "Mending the Pen After Losing a Sheep"

**The Story:** A shepherd lost sheep because his pen had a hole. A neighbor advised him to fix it, but he shrugged — the sheep were already gone. After losing more, he finally repaired the pen. Better late than never.

- **Characters:** 亡羊补牢
- **Pinyin:** wáng yáng bǔ láo
- **Meaning:** It's never too late to fix a problem
- **Example:** 虽然考试没考好，但亡羊补牢，现在开始认真复习还来得及。(Suī rán kǎo shì méi kǎo hǎo, dàn wáng yáng bǔ láo, xiàn zài kāi shǐ rèn zhēn fù xí hái lái de jí.) — "The exam didn't go well, but it's not too late — start reviewing seriously now."

11. 半途而废 (bàn tú ér fèi) — "Giving Up Halfway"

- **Characters:** 半途而废
- **Pinyin:** bàn tú ér fèi
- **Meaning:** Abandoning something before finishing; quitting midway
- **Example:** 学语言最怕半途而废，一定要坚持。(Xué yǔ yǎn zuì pà bàn tú ér fèi, yí dìng yào jiān chí.) — "The worst thing in language learning is giving up halfway — you must persist."

12. 举一反三 (jǔ yī fǎn sān) — "Learn One, Infer Three"

This chengyu comes from the *Analerta of Confucius*. The Master said: "If I show a student one corner of a topic and they cannot infer the other three, I won't repeat the lesson."

- **Characters:** 举一反三
- **Pinyin:** jǔ yī fǎn sān
- **Meaning:** Drawing broader conclusions from a single example; quick to learn
- **Example:** 好学生能举一反三，不用老师反复讲解。(Hǎo xué shēng néng jǔ yī fǎn sān, bú yòng lǎo shī fǎn fù jiǎng jiě.) — "Good students can infer broadly from one example without the teacher repeating."

## How to Use Chengyu in Conversation

Using Chinese idioms correctly isn't just about memorization — it's about context. Here are practical tips:

**1. Start with common ones.** Idioms like 加油 (jiā yóu, "keep going!") and 马马虎虎 (mǎ mǎ hū hū, "so-so") are already part of everyday speech. Build from there.

**2. Match the register.** Some chengyu sound literary and formal. Using 高瞻远瞩 (gāo zhān yuǎn zhǔ, "visionary") in casual chat might sound odd. Stick to colloquial-friendly idioms for spoken Mandarin.

**3. Use them as comments, not translations.** Native speakers drop chengyu as reactions — after describing a situation, they summarize it with a four-character phrase. Mimic this pattern.

If you're building your Chinese vocabulary foundations, our guide on [proven memory techniques for Chinese characters](#) covers the science behind why story-based learning works so well for character retention.

## Chinese Idioms vs. Chinese Proverbs and Sayings

Learners often mix up the terms. Here's a quick breakdown:

| Term                       | Chinese        | Length                        | Example     |
|----------------------------|----------------|-------------------------------|-------------|
| Chengyu (idiom)            | 成语 (chéngyǔ)   | Exactly 4 characters          | 画蛇添足        |
| Proverb                    | 谚语 (yànyǔ)     | Variable, often 7+ characters | 三个臭皮匠，顶个诸葛亮 |
| Saying / Expression        | 俗语 (súyǔ)      | Variable                      | 吃一堑，长一智     |
| Xiehouyu (two-part riddle) | 歇后语 (xiēhòuyǔ) | Two clauses                   | 猫哭耗子——假慈悲   |

All of these fall under the umbrella of **Chinese sayings**, but chengyu are the most structured and the most frequently tested in HSK exams. For a broader introduction to Mandarin and how long it takes to reach each proficiency level, see our [Chinese learning timeline guide](#).

## Tips for Learning Chinese Idioms Effectively

**Learn the story first.** As you've seen in this guide, every famous chengyu has a vivid tale behind it. When you know the story, the four characters become a mental shortcut — not an arbitrary string.

**Practice in context.** Don't just memorize the idiom — use it in a sentence. Better yet, type it out. Active recall through typing reinforces character recognition and pinyin accuracy far more effectively than passive reading. Our [complete guide to learning Chinese by typing](#) explains the science behind this approach.

**Group by theme.** Notice how this guide groups idioms by effort, mistakes, wisdom, and learning? Creating thematic clusters helps your brain organize and retrieve them faster.

**Start with 20.** There are thousands of chengyu, but you don't need them all. The idioms in this guide represent some of the most frequently used Chinese idioms in modern conversation. Master these first before expanding your collection.